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REMARKS OF THE PRESIDENT
 UPON DEPARTURE FROM REYKJAVIK, ICELAND

Reykjavik International Airport
 Reykjavik, Iceland

11/14/89 (1)

THE PRESIDENT: Thank you very much, Ambassador Ruve, Admiral Hovelson, men and women of our Armed Forces and my fellow Americans. Thank you all. It's good to feel so at home. (Applause.) And I want to apologize for being so late.

As you know, General Secretary Gorbachev and I were to have concluded our talks at noon, after more than seven and a half hours of meetings over the last two days. But when the hour for departure arrived, we both felt that further discussions would be valuable. So I called Nancy and told her I wouldn't be home for dinner. (Laughter.) She said she understood; in about six and a half hours, I'll find out. (Laughter.)

Well, the talks we've just concluded were hard and tough, and yet I have to say extremely useful. We spoke about arms control, both in Europe and regional conflicts, and of course, Mr. Gorbachev and I were frank about our disagreements. We had to be. In several critical areas, we made more progress than we anticipated when we came to Iceland. We moved toward agreement on drastically reduced numbers of intermediate-range nuclear missiles in both Europe and Asia.

We approached agreement on sharply reduced strategic arsenals for both our countries. We made progress in the area of nuclear testing. But there remained, at the end of our talks, one area of disagreement. While both sides seek reduction in the number of nuclear missiles and warheads threatening the world, the Soviet Union insisted that we sign an agreement that would deny to me and to future presidents for ten years the right to develop, test and deploy a defense against nuclear missiles for the people of the free world. This, we could not and will not do. (Applause.)

So late this afternoon, I made to the General Secretary an entirely new proposal: a ten-year delay in deployment of SDI in exchange for the complete elimination of all ballistic missiles from the respective arsenals of both nations. So long as both the United States and the Soviet Union prove their good faith by destroying nuclear missiles year by year, we would not deploy SDI.

The General Secretary said he would consider our offer, but only if we restricted all work on SDI to laboratory research, which would have killed our defensive shield.

We came to Iceland to advance the cause of peace, and to work on the table the arms-reducing arms control. However, the General Secretary rejected it. However, we will continue in Iceland in resolving most of our differences and to continue the effort.

But this brings me to my main reason in coming to Reykjavik. To say you all and express my gratitude, gratitude to you all for the importance of your

and it always held a strategic position in the
 world. You will see the line between the old world and
 the new. I have to be careful of this
 line. The first
 line is the foot: north
 the foot: north
 the foot: north

During World War II, Iceland played a crucial role in the
 war. Early in the war, German U-boats began to exact
 tolls, including the shipping that supplied the British
 from the United States. Between March and December,
 German U-boats sank ships, totaling more than a million tons.

Churchill worried with growing disquiet as his nation was
 on the verge of starvation. In April of 1941, the
 British established bases on his island for secret groups and
 aircraft. In July, we joined them, with the consent of the Icelandic
 authorities, with bases of our own.

These operations staged from this very island proved
 decisive in the balance of the entire struggle. In Churchill's
 words, "The secret groups became ever more efficient and as their
 power grew, that of the U-boats declined. Europe was saved to
 continue the struggle for freedom."

I cite all this history because if Iceland was crucial to
 the cause of freedom then, it is even more important today. The U.S.
 and Iceland are joined together as members of NATO. And here you
 are, thousands of miles from home, closer, indeed, to the Soviet
 naval bases on the Kola Peninsula than to our own East Coast.

In view of those naval bases and other potential threats,
 you serve as a vanguard for Iceland, the United States, and all the
 NATO allies. You monitor military air traffic, you track submarines,
 and you monitor shipping movements in the vital sea lanes between the
 United States, Iceland, and Europe.

You perform all these tasks with efficiency and
 dedication. In short, with a keen sense of duty. And, ladies and
 gentlemen of our Armed Forces, on behalf of a grateful
 Commander-in-Chief, I salute you. (Applause.)

I can't resist telling you a little story that I've just
 told the Marine guard at the Embassy.

The story has to do with saluting. I was a second
 lieutenant of horse cavalry back in the World War II days. As I told
 the Admiral, I wound up flying a desk in the Army Air Force. And so
 I knew all the rules about not saluting in civilian clothes and to
 forbear, and when you should or shouldn't, but then when I got this job
 -- (laughter) -- and I would be approaching all these one or Marine
 One and those Marines would come to a salute and, knowing that I am
 in civilian clothes -- I would not and say hello and I think they could
 do, their hands, and they wouldn't. They just said there.

So one night over at the Commandant's quarters -- Marine
 Commandant's quarters in Washington -- and I was visiting a couple of
 highballs and I didn't -- (laughter) -- know what to do with them, so
 I got to the Commandant's. I said, "Look, I know all the rules about
 saluting in civilian clothes and all, but if I see the
 Commandant-in-Chief, there ought to be a regulation that would permit
 me to salute a salute." But I heard some words of wisdom. He said,
 "If you see the Commandant-in-Chief, you salute him." (laughter) and

If you see the Commandant-in-Chief and I'm saluting, you know
 you salute him. (laughter) -- and I do it

So you see, in some people here I can't salute,

... apples, the civilians. But seeing them does bring to
... families make. So whether your
... the next time you see them or write a
... (Applause.)

... to us we have one more round of applause still
... that we've included could never have been had it
... the generosity of the people of Iceland. (Applause.)

... it's time to go now, Nancy's waiting dinner.
... After all, Congress is still in session, and I have to
... and keep an eye on them. (Laughter.) Sometimes they get
... about reducing pay rates for the military. (Applause.)
... don't worry, I'll never let them. (Applause.)

... since I'm so far away from them right now -- (Laughter)
... going to take a chance and tell you a little story, I think,
... about them. (Laughter.) You know, when I think of them sometimes,
... particularly the opposition that wants to do those ridiculous
... things, I think of those three fellows that came out of a building
... one day and found they'd locked themselves out of their car. And one
... of them said, "Well, somebody get a wire goathanger." And he said,
... "I can straighten it out and use it and get in and flip the handle
... and open it." And the second one said, "You can't do that. Somebody
... would see you doing it and think you're stealing the car." And the
... third one said, "Well, we'd better do something pretty quick, because
... it's starting to rain and the top's down." (Laughter.) (Applause.)

But, in closing, let me say simply this: you are not
... here on NATO's frontline, you're not making the sacrifice of leaving
... home and friends so far behind merely to keep the world from getting
... worse. You're here to make it better, for you're here in the name of
... liberty. Yes, the -- (Applause) -- yes, the ultimate goal of
... American foreign policy is not just the prevention of war, but the
... expansion of freedom -- to see that every nation, every people, every
... person, some day enjoys the blessings of liberty. All that you do
... has strengthened world peace, the peace in which the flame of freedom
... continues to burn and spread its light throughout the world.

I have to tell you that of all the things that I'm proud
... of in this job, none match the pride that I have in those of you who
... are wearing the uniform of your country -- you young men and women --
... God bless you.

Many years ago, the beginning of World War II, General
... George Marshall was asked, what was our secret weapon. And he said
... then, just the best blankety-blank kids in the world. Well, I have
... to tell you, we've still got that secret weapon.

God bless all of you. Thank you very much. (Applause.)

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